

School gardens for primary schools: concept note and funder map

Prepared 8 September 2026 by Joshua Matalon as a sample of a first grant deliverable. The applicant organisation and its programme numbers are illustrative; every funder fact on page 2 is real and sourced.

A district school-garden programme that gives a hot midday meal to pupils in six primary schools by growing part of it on school land, with parents doing the growing and the school selling the surplus. The concept note is the two pages a programme officer reads first. The funder map is the list of who could pay for it, in the order they should be approached, with what each one requires.

THE PROBLEM THE PROGRAMME ANSWERS

Uganda's government and the World Food Programme are moving school feeding toward a home-grown model, where schools source meals from local production rather than external rations; the WFP Uganda country office sought national partners in 2026 to support the 2026 to 2030 school feeding strategy on exactly this basis.¹ The Novo Nordisk Foundation and the Grundfos Foundation committed up to \$77.75 million and \$3.1 million respectively, through WFP, to expand home-grown school feeding in Uganda, Kenya and Ethiopia.² Most of that money reaches schools through government and large agencies. A district organisation with six partner schools does not qualify for it directly, and needs a bridge: small grants that fund the garden, the kitchen and the first two growing seasons until the model pays for itself.

WHAT IS PROPOSED

Element	Detail
Where	Six government-aided primary schools in one district, chosen for having at least a quarter hectare of usable land and a parent-teacher association willing to run a garden roster.
What is built	A fenced garden with a rainwater tank and drip line, a covered cooking shelter with two energy-saving stoves, and a store. Standard designs, built by local contractors.
Who grows	A parent roster of twenty households per school, trained over one season by a district agricultural officer, growing beans, maize, orange-fleshed sweet potato and leafy greens on a rotation.
Who eats	Every pupil, every school day, one meal. Enrolment across the six schools is the programme's headline number and is confirmed from the schools' registers before any budget is fixed.
How it lasts	Surplus is sold at the school gate; proceeds pay the cook's stipend and replace seed and tools. Year three is the first year with no external food purchase in the plan.
What is measured	Meals served per pupil per term from the cook's log; attendance from the school register, compared with the same term the year before; garden yield by crop from the roster's harvest sheet.

ILLUSTRATIVE BUDGET, FIRST TWO YEARS

Line	Per school, \$	Six schools, \$	Note
Garden works: fencing, tank, drip line, tools	2,400	14,400	Local contractor quotes obtained before submission
Cooking shelter, two stoves, store	1,800	10,800	Standard design shared across schools
Seed, seedlings and inputs, two seasons	450	2,700	Falls to zero from year three
Bridging food purchase, first two terms	1,200	7,200	Until the first harvest
Training, agricultural officer, four visits per season	300	1,800	District officer's time, paid at government rate
Cook stipend, two years	960	5,760	Taken over by gate sales from year three
Monitoring and reporting	—	2,400	One field visit per school per term
Total	7,110	45,060	

The budget is illustrative and unrounded on purpose, so a reader can see how the lines build up. A real submission replaces every line with a quote or a rate and names its source.

WHY THIS SHAPE

The structure follows what the funders on the next page say they will and will not fund. Capital and training are one-time and bounded, which suits small foundation grants. The recurring cost is designed to disappear, which is what every funder on the map asks about first. Nothing in the plan depends on a single large donor: the total splits into three grants of the sizes the mapped funders actually give.

FUNDER MAP

Ten funders checked against this programme on 8 September 2026. Fit A means the programme matches the funder's stated priorities and route; B means it fits with a condition; C means it does not fit now and is listed so the reader knows it was considered. Every row cites the page the facts came from.

Funder	What they fund, as stated	Size and route	Status for this programme	Fit
Hilden Charitable Fund (UK) ³	Smaller organisations in Malawi, Tanzania and Uganda; access to education for women and girls, or rural communities becoming more self-sufficient.	Up to £5,000 a year for up to two years. Online portal. One country per year; Uganda's window is February to March 2027.	Applicant must be a Uganda-registered NGO for at least six months before applying. Prepare now, submit in the 2027 window.	A
The Waterloo Foundation, World Development (UK) ⁴	Women and girls in education, hygiene and health, including nutrition; priority to countries low on the UNDP Human Development Index. Has funded a school feeding programme tied to a water source.	Applications by email to the address on the guidelines page. Read the programme page before writing.	Open. Frame the proposal around girls' attendance and nutrition, with the garden as the mechanism.	A
Global Fund for Children (US) ⁵	Community-based organisations serving marginalised children and youth; education, gender justice, youth power.	Letter of inquiry accepted at any time; new grants awarded twice a year, June and December.	Open. A letter of inquiry can go now; expect the December round.	A
The Pollination Project (US) ⁶	Grassroots changemakers and early-stage nonprofits with budgets under \$50,000, worldwide; education is a listed topic.	Seed grants up to \$1,000, rolling; applications made before month end are reviewed the following month.	Open. Right size for one school's seed and tools; useful as a first funded line to cite.	B
Segal Family Foundation (US) ⁷	African-led grassroots organisations in East Africa; trust-based, multi-year.	First grants typically \$10,000 to \$40,000. No open application; referrals through current partners or a basic contact form.	Route is a warm introduction via a current grantee in Uganda. Start with the contact form and the partner list.	B
Together Women Rise (US) ⁸	Organisations empowering women and girls in the Global South; has funded permagarden programmes in Uganda.	\$35,000 to \$50,000 over 24 months. Eligibility questionnaire, then profile, then full application.	Requires three years of operation, a budget of at least \$100,000, majority-women leadership and US 501(c)(3) status or a fiscal sponsor. Fits a later stage.	B
Rotary Foundation global grant ⁹	Humanitarian projects in Rotary's areas of focus, which include basic education and disease prevention.	Minimum \$30,000 budget; requires a host Rotary club in Uganda and an international partner club; needs assessment required.	Feasible only with two sponsoring clubs. Worth one approach to the nearest Rotary club; not a first move.	B
WFP Uganda, school feeding partnership ¹	National institutions to strengthen school feeding systems, policy and financing, 2026 to 2029.	Expression of interest; the 2026 call closed in April.	Not for a district organisation. Watch for district-level calls under the 2026 to 2030 strategy.	C
Firelight Foundation (US) ¹⁰	Community-based organisations improving children's lives in eastern and southern Africa; past grants in Uganda.	Does not accept unsolicited proposals.	Listed so the reader knows it was checked. Approach only through a referral.	C
Slow Food, Gardens in Africa ¹¹	A network that creates school and community gardens in Uganda through the local Slow Food network; supporters adopt a garden.	Not a grant maker. Partnership and adoption model.	A partner for training and visibility, not a funder. Contact the Uganda network before submitting to funders that value it.	C

ORDER OF APPROACH

1. Send the Global Fund for Children letter of inquiry this month; it costs nothing and sets the December clock.

2. Write the Waterloo Foundation proposal around girls' attendance; submit when the enrolment figures are confirmed.
3. Apply to the Pollination Project for one school's seed and tools, to have a funded line before larger asks.
4. Register the organisation's date and documents now so the Hilden window in February 2027 is not missed.
5. Use the contact form and partner list at Segal to find one Ugandan grantee willing to make an introduction.

SOURCES

1. WFP Uganda, call for expressions of interest, "Strengthening school feeding systems (Uganda)", as listed at <https://www2.fundsforngos.org/community-development-2/call-for-eois-strengthening-school-feeding-systems-uganda/> (deadline 17 April 2026; partners from 1 November 2026 to 31 October 2029). Accessed 8 September 2026.
2. fundsforNGOs News, "Major private-sector push to transform school meals in East Africa", 8 May 2026, <https://news.fundsforngos.org/2026/05/08/major-private-sector-push-to-transform-school-meals-in-east-africa/> (Novo Nordisk Foundation up to \$77.75 million; Grundfos Foundation \$3.1 million over three years; WFP; Uganda, Kenya, Ethiopia).
3. Hilden Charitable Fund, "Overseas funding", <https://hildencharitablefund.org/overseas-funding/> (up to £5,000 a year for up to two years; Malawi, Tanzania and Uganda; one country per year, Uganda February to March 2027; NGO registered in country at least six months).
4. The Waterloo Foundation, "World Development" and "World Development application guidelines", <https://waterloofoundation.org.uk/worlddevelopment/> and <https://waterloofoundation.org.uk/worlddevelopmentapplications/>.
5. Global Fund for Children, "Africa", <https://globalfundforchildren.org/region/africa/>; partner inquiry process as summarised at <https://www.instrumentl.com/grants/global-fund-for-children-become-a-partner> (letters of inquiry any time; grants awarded June and December).
6. The Pollination Project, "Getting started with your application", <https://thepollinationproject.org/apply/> (up to \$1,000; rolling; early-stage nonprofits under \$50,000 budget).
7. Segal Family Foundation, "FAQ", <https://www.segalfamilyfoundation.org/who-we-are/faq/>, and Inside Philanthropy profile, <https://www.insidephilanthropy.com/find-a-grant/grants-s/segal-family-foundation-2> (no unsolicited proposals; first grants \$10,000 to \$40,000; contact form).
8. Together Women Rise, "Featured grant guidelines", <https://togetherwomenrise.org/featured-grant-guidelines/> (\$35,000 to \$50,000 over 24 months; three years operating; budget at least \$100,000; majority-women leadership; 501(c)(3) or fiscal sponsor); Uganda permagarden grantee at <https://togetherwomenrise.org/programfactsheets/african-women-rising/>.
9. Rotary International, "Global grants", <https://www.rotary.org/globalgrants> (minimum budget \$30,000; host and international sponsor clubs; needs assessment).
10. Inside Philanthropy, "Firelight Foundation", <https://www.insidephilanthropy.com/find-a-grant/grants-f/firelight-foundation> (does not accept unsolicited proposals; past grants in Uganda).
11. Slow Food, "Food gardens in Africa", <https://www.slowfood.com/biodiversity-programs/food-gardens/>, and Slow Food Foundation, "Support a garden in Africa", <https://www.fondazioneSlowFood.com/en/what-we-do/10-000-gardens-in-africa-2/support-a-garden-in-africa/>.